women at the time was focused almost entirely on social issues: such as its nationwide campaign against dowry as a ‘social evil’ in 1982[49] or its move to set up a legal cell for rape cases in 1984.[50] Women’s issues were not at the forefront of its politics. For example, when Vijaya Raje Scindia circulated a signed ten-page vision paper for discussion at the BJP’s National Executive in 1981, the word ‘woman’ did not feature in it even once.[51] The failure to attract women voters was a major reason why the party fell to an abysmal two seats in the 1984 general election. When Vajpayee commissioned a twelve-member inquiry into the reasons behind this wipe-out, the Working Group listed several—key among which was the ‘poor response from women and Party units’ failure to pay special attention and care towards this section’.[52] Arguing that the BJP ‘cannot grow merely on traditional cadres’ who may be a strong core group, but were ‘too small in numbers looking to the needs of an all Indian wide political party’, the Working Group made eight specific recommendations to attract new voters. The need to attract women voters featured high on this blueprint at Number 3. As the report put it, ‘Bring in women leadership at all levels of organisation and encourage youth in our party.’[53]

Figure 17.3: BJP Mahila Morcha’s Inaugural Meeting at the BJP’s First Plenary, 1980